

My parents introduced my wife and I to their financial advisor. Based on this referral, we trusted the advisor blindly. We had a substantial amount to invest due to our high savings rate.

We later learned we paid approximately eight times more in hidden fees than we thought we were, costing us thousands of dollars each year. Following horrible advice led to costly tax planning blunders that cost thousands more. This combination of excessive hidden fees and unnecessary taxes cost us nearly \$20,000 in just one year. But we weren't ignorant just once. We willingly followed this advice for nearly a decade before taking the time to educate ourselves. Blindly trusting an advisor with our money was easily a million-dollar mistake.

The magnitude of our mistakes was extraordinary because our high savings rate enabled us to invest so much money so quickly. But many people share the same misconceptions that set us up for these mistakes. It's common to think investing is confusing, overwhelming, and impossible to do on your own. This is not an accident. There is a tremendous incentive for the financial industry to promote feelings of inadequacy, fear, and confusion in investors. Creating complexity and anxiety allows the financial advice industry to justify their existence. None of this creates value. Instead, it promotes